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EDITORIAL

JOURNAL OF PRODUCT INNOVATION MANAGEMENT

Preparing a successful submission for JPIM

1 | INTRODUCTION

As we write this editorial, we have just completed our first quarter as Co-Editors-in-Chief (Co-EiCs) of JPIM. During these 3 months, we received approximately 200 new submissions, which provided us with an initial evidence base of the breadth and depth of the research articles that JPIM attracts. We are very encouraged by the vibrancy of JPIM's pipeline and thank all the authors who continue to target JPIM for publishing their work.

The purpose of this editorial is to provide guidance to authors who wish to submit a new manuscript to JPIM. We focus on original research articles rather than on the other two special article categories (i.e., Catalyst essays and Review articles), which follow different guidelines available on our website. While the guidance offered here is useful in general, we particularly aim to reach out to researchers who may be new to JPIM, such as doctoral students, early-career researchers, or scholars from disciplines outside business (e.g., engineering and computer science), who are attracted by the interdisciplinary nature of JPIM.

We address the following question: *how to prepare a successful submission for JPIM*? A successful submission is one that is eventually published. The first hurdle on the route to publication is desk rejection (i.e., immediate rejection without review). At JPIM, this decision is made directly by us as Co-EiCs, usually within 2 weeks from the submission date. We desk-reject submissions that fall short of the criteria required to have a reasonable chance to fare well in the review process. Desk rejections help us—as Co-EiCs—to optimize the work of our reviewers and Editorial Review Board (ERB) members by not committing their time and effort to review manuscripts whose rejection we can largely anticipate. In doing so, we aim to lower the volume and increase the quality of manuscripts that JPIM reviewers are invited to read and assess while shortening the time between submission and first decision. This will result, in turn, in a better experience for both authors and reviewers. JPIM has a high desk-rejection rate (70% or above). Thus, guidance on how to get past a desk rejection should be useful for a large segment of authors. Hence, we rephrase our initial question as *how to prepare a submission that makes it past the desk-rejection decision at JPIM*? We highlight five key conditions that address this question, drawing on our experience so far.

2 | FIT WITH JPIM SCOPE

Innovation involves the ideation, design, development, and commercialization/adoption of a new offering, process, or practice that creates value for stakeholders. JPIM's scope is how individuals, teams, organizations, and networks improve their ability to understand, perform, and manage innovation. The first success factor to be met by new submissions is to fit the scope of JPIM. Within this scope, we welcome diverse theoretical perspectives and methodological approaches. Surprisingly, we often receive manuscripts outside the scope of JPIM. Some examples include highly technical manuscripts describing technologies and their applications, descriptive case studies of individual companies, or manuscripts that focus exclusively on other disciplines and lack a clear connection to innovation management theory or practice.

3 | A CLEAR AND NOVEL RESEARCH QUESTION

The second condition is to include a clear and novel research question that captures the interests of a relevant section of JPIM's audience, including researchers and practitioners, because it addresses an unsolved puzzle. Some of the submissions that we receive fail this test as they do not clearly spell out their research question. In other cases, the research question is included but has already been answered in prior research. Highly salient topics around which innovation management scholars and practitioners converge are a more fertile ground to identify research questions that resonate with JPIM's audience and will result in new knowledge creation (e.g., Spanjol et al., 2024). To do so, authors are encouraged to read and build on the latest research published in JPIM and other leading journals publishing innovation management research. While this might seem obvious,

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manuscripts do get desk rejected due to insufficient grounding in the extant innovation management literature and/or failure to extend the boundaries of knowledge as drawn by this extant literature.

4 | ECOLOGICAL VALUE

Good research questions for JPIM identify a puzzle whose solution requires new theoretical explanations that inform the practice of innovation management (Dorobantu et al., 2024). At JPIM, we strongly emphasize the importance of managerial and policy implications, in addition to the theoretical contributions as expected by most academic journals. Rather than being an afterthought, managerial and policy implications should flow naturally from research puzzles that are strongly rooted in the real world of innovation management, rather than conjectured by researchers insulated from the natural context of the phenomenon. This notion is also referred to as the ecological value of research, described as the extent to which research reflects and is relevant to the way actors, stakeholders, and ecosystems experience the existence of a phenomenon in real-world settings (van Heerde et al., 2021). Ecological value stems from the choice of a research topic that connects to real-world examples and trends, and should permeate every aspect of the research process, including theory development, research design, data collection, analysis, and reporting (van Heerde et al., 2021). Some of the submissions we receive are somewhat disconnected from the challenges of real-world innovation practice and have little or no implications for managers and policymakers. These manuscripts are typically desk rejected.

5 | GOOD EXECUTION

Satisfying the criteria listed thus far is a necessary but not sufficient condition for a successful submission to JPIM. Establishing a fit with the journal, including a novel research question, and being in-sync with the real-world, may be described as "front-end" tasks in the process of developing a new publication project. Once these choices are locked-in, the manuscript development process enters an execution or "back-end" stage, characterized by the more formal and disciplined implementation of literature review, hypothesis development, data collection, data analysis and writing tasks. The quality with which these research tasks are executed can either realize or hinder the potential of a manuscript. In fact, even manuscripts with a highly promising "front-end" could not get past the EiC desk due to poor execution; for example, relevant literature is ignored or misinterpreted; the theoretical framework and hypotheses are not conceptually rigorous and logically sound; the sample and/or the data collected are not appropriate in order to answer the research question; measures lack validity and reliability; the data analysis is not rigorous/not replicable/not ethically conducted; and/or the manuscript is poorly written, figures and tables are not informative and professionally presented, and so forth.

Sometimes, these "back-end" or execution issues may be fixed during the review process, so they are not always associated with a desk-rejection; however, when a manuscript is affected by low-quality execution in two or more aspects simultaneously, the chances of successfully improving the manuscript within an equitable review process are too thin, which usually leads to a desk-rejection decision.

6 | ADHERENCE TO ETHICAL STANDARDS

JPIM has developed ethical guidelines that reflect what we consider proper behavior in terms of publishing within our journal. Not following these ethical guidelines will result in a desk rejection. Assessment of adherence to JPIM ethical guidelines is facilitated by dedicated software tools embedded in our manuscript submission platform. The main ethical guidelines are summarized as follows. First, we do not allow the resubmission of previously submitted and (desk) rejected manuscripts, even when the manuscript was revised with new data. Furthermore, we desk reject manuscripts that show too much overlap with previously published articles (i.e., cases of plagiarism), including work published by the authors themselves. In addition, we desk reject manuscripts from so-called "paper mills," that is, fraudulent commercial entities that make money by writing fabricated manuscripts and offer authorship positions for sale (Parker et al., 2024). Finally, we desk reject manuscripts that do not adhere to JPIM policies regarding the use of GenAI tools. These guidelines were discussed in greater depth in an editorial by the prior Co-EiCs (Spanjol & Noble, 2023) and stipulate, among other things, the need for full transparency on the use of GenAI tools and preclude GenAI tools from being listed as a (co)author.

To recap, a practical and useful checklist that authors can use before submitting their manuscript to JPIM includes the following questions:

- Does our manuscript fit with JPIM's scope?
- Is our research question novel and relevant for JPIM's audience?

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- Do we tackle a real-world innovation management puzzle?
- Have we executed our manuscript in line with JPIM's standards for quality and ethics?

We conclude this editorial with some useful tips to authors on how they can answer the above questions more confidently, especially when they lack prior experience with JPIM's editorial review process. First, we recommend reading recent JPIM articles that match their research topic and/or methods to form a better idea of the benchmarks for contribution, rigor, relevance, and style. Next, it is always recommended to consult our guidelines for authors published on JPIM's website to ensure that new submissions fit JPIM's scope and comply with the expected content and format. In addition, to receive valuable feedback on the above criteria ahead of a submission, authors can invite a friendly review from colleagues who have successfully published in JPIM before; also, they can submit their work to key innovation management conferences, such as the annual JPIM Research Forum and the Innovation and Product Development Management Conference (IPDMC), where they can connect with the JPIM community and receive valuable feedback from expert researchers; and finally, they can target one of our paper development workshops (PDWs) as an opportunity to further develop and finalize their manuscripts. PDWs are unique and excellent occasions where aspiring JPIM authors receive an overall fit assessment while working with the editorial staff of the journal. These activities require investing time, effort, and resources but will improve the odds of a successful submission to JPIM.

As Co-EiCs, we encourage new authors to submit their best innovation-related work to JPIM so that our journal grows together with its community. In doing so, we hope that the guidance offered in this editorial serves the needs of both new and existing JPIM authors.

CONFLICT OF INTEREST STATEMENT

The authors declare no conflict of interest.

ETHICS STATEMENT

The authors have read and agreed to the Committee on Publication Ethics (COPE) international standards for authors.

DATA AVAILABILITY STATEMENT

Data sharing is not applicable to this article as no new data were created or analyzed in this study.

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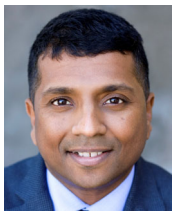

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